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The People Who Held Me Together: My Life With Bipolar

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This is for the people I care about.

For years I kept what was happening inside me to myself: living with what my doctors diagnosed as bipolar disorder, and everything that came with it. I know that left many of you with only pieces of the story. Moments that didn't make sense, silences you couldn't explain, hurt you never deserved. This is my attempt to give you the whole picture: where it started, what it looked like from the inside, and where you fit into it.

It is, first of all, an apology to the people I hurt along the way. It is a thank-you to the people who held me together anyway. And I hope it brings you some understanding, and with it some peace, so that whatever you have been carrying from our time together, you can finally set it down.

Where it starts: my father



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My father wasn't bipolar. He had schizophrenia, and was diagnosed with schizoaffective disorder, which is schizophrenia together with mood episodes: the highs and the depressions. I grew up with it in the house. I didn't have words for it as a kid, but I knew the weather could change without warning.

He was 302'd many times. In Pennsylvania, a "302" is an involuntary emergency psychiatric commitment, named for the section of the law that allows it. Each one was a crisis for him and for all of us, and our family dealt with it again and again. Later I watched him decline, in and out of hospitals, sedated by medication, less and less himself.

Eventually my mom divorced him. From the outside it might have looked as if she left him high and dry. She didn't. She cared for him, and she stuck it out for the longest time before she finally had to.

Mental illness runs in my family. My father's diagnosis and mine aren't the same, but they're related: schizophrenia, schizoaffective disorder and bipolar disorder share much of their genetic risk, and having a parent with one raises a child's risk of the others. I knew that intellectually for a long time. What I didn't expect was to catch myself doing the things I remembered him doing.

My mom



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If my father is where some of this started, my mom is where so much of who I am comes from. My personality is hers. I learned what unconditional love is from her: first by receiving it, and then by watching her care for my father for as long as she possibly could.

She is an angel and a saint. I have never known her to hurt anyone. She shaped the person I am, and whatever emotional intelligence I have, I learned from her.

I spent so much time with her. She taught me to garden and to cross-stitch. We had tea together. I helped her bake cookies, and I got to lick the batter off the spoon.

I've always found it easier to connect with women. In my experience they meet me at that emotional level, the one she taught me to live at. I think that's her influence too, and you'll see it later in this post, in the people who held me together.

She's living with dementia and memory loss now. Whatever she forgets, what she taught me stays.

Looking back: the obsessions



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Looking back, there was a pattern long before any diagnosis. When something caught me, it caught me completely.

As a kid it was skiing. I'd watch ski movies with the sound off so I could focus on the details: how the skis carved the snow, turn after turn. Later it was mountain biking, and I pored over every component and every kind of bike.

It shows up with food and routines too. I went through a phase of drinking a twelve-pack of LaCroix a day, with a stockpile of it in the garage. Same with blueberries and yogurt. I go through stretches where I lock onto one food, one activity or one routine, and do it over and over.

And it hasn't stopped. These days it's ping pong, and I'm every bit as consumed by it as I once was by skiing: the spin, the rhythm, the pull to get a little better every time I pick up a paddle. Something new catches me, and it catches me completely, the same way it always has.

I don't know how much of that is the illness and how much is simply who I am. But I recognize the same all-in intensity in my highs, and it was there long before I had a word for any of it.

The part that feels good



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Nobody warns you that the high is the part you'll miss.

When I was up, the world was easy. I felt like I was floating through it. Problems that normally took real effort just dissolved. I needed very little sleep and didn't feel tired. I had ideas faster than I could write them down, and every one of them felt obviously right.

My body became something to spend:

- **The gym twice a day.** Morning and evening, pushing harder each time. I wore my body down and told myself it was discipline.

- **Clubs and dancing.** Late nights, loud music, being out when I'd normally be home. I felt magnetic, and for a while I was.
- **A flood of new friends.** I collected people fast. Conversations were electric and plans multiplied. I've never been more social in my life.

From the inside it doesn't feel like an illness. It feels like finally becoming the person you were supposed to be. That's exactly what makes it dangerous.

The part that doesn't



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The same energy has another edge.

I got **aggressive** with people: short-tempered, confrontational, sure I was right and irritated that others couldn't keep up. People who loved me started to feel like obstacles.

I **lied**. Not grand schemes, but a steady stream of small untruths to cover where I'd been, what I'd spent, how late it was, how much I'd done. Each lie seemed justified in the moment, and each one cost me some trust that I haven't fully earned back.

Then there's the crash. Every high I've had has been followed by a low, and the lows are not sadness. Depression is an absence. The ideas stop. The energy is gone. The friends I collected so fast drifted away just as fast, partly because I stopped reaching out. I went quiet for weeks or months and fell out of touch with nearly everyone. From the outside that looks like you stopped caring. From the inside, answering a text feels like lifting a car.

And here is the part I still find hardest to explain. I have made more friends in these years than at any other time in my life: a full calendar, a phone full of names, a room full of people who were glad to see me. And I have never been lonelier.

I have never had more friends, and I have never felt more alone.

The highs made me easy to like and hard to know. Most of those friends only ever met the person I was on the way up. Very few saw the person I became on the way down, because by then I had stopped answering.

The people around me

This is the hardest section to write.

My ex-wife spent years as part of a team trying to get me well, driving to appointments, tracking medications, filling out forms and absorbing the fallout. Living with someone whose personality changes with the season is exhausting, and she carried more of it than anyone should have to. Our marriage ended, for many reasons and not just this one. But I won't pretend my illness wasn't one of them.



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My boys are the reason I kept going to appointments on days I didn't want to. They saw the loud, over-scheduled, too-intense version of their dad, and they saw the version that couldn't get off the couch. I think about my own childhood with my father, and I work very hard for my story to end differently for them.

My older son has become my best friend. He went and researched all of this on his own, and he understands it deeply. We've had many conversations about it. He's always there. He is so caring and so loving, a young man now, and he shares his love of all things technology with me.

My younger son is my best friend too, and my skiing buddy. He's quiet and sweet, and he knows everything that's going on. He was very young when all of this happened, and he was hurt a lot by it. He lived through much of the bad stuff, wondering why his dad was leaving. He knew about the divorce before I did. He could sense it coming, and he would say, "Dad, don't get divorced."

Friends came and went with my moods. I'm not proud of how many relationships I let lapse. If you're one of them: it wasn't you.

The people who held me together

Not everything in these years was loss. Some of the best of it came from people who didn't have to show up for me at all.

Not all of these stories have happy endings, and where they don't, much of that is on me. But the way a chapter ends doesn't erase what it gave. If you find yourself in this section, I want you to know that you mattered, that you still do, and that I carry what you gave me. This is my thank-you, and where I owe one, my apology.

Shirley (Doc)



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Early on, before I understood much of what was happening to me, there was Shirley, who I've always called Doc. We met while I was still married, on a date at a coffee shop, and agreed we were better as friends. That turned out to be one of the best decisions either of us made.

We went on many hikes. She had a saying for everything, and real wisdom behind every one of them. When my marriage ended, she helped me process the divorce. She gave me a playlist of songs about love and heartbreak, and I still play it, over and over, to this day. We played Scrabble.

She did all of this with almost no time to spare. She was in school then, on her way to becoming an anesthesiologist, working night shifts as a nurse and raising two daughters. She knew I was hurting. She saw it, and she took it on herself to make time for me anyway, in a schedule that had none. She made herself a big part of my healing.

Her smile and her passion for life are huge, and they're contagious. Shirley, thank you. You were there at the very beginning of this, before I even knew what it was, and you made sure I wasn't facing it alone.

Lindsay



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Lindsay was my first relationship after my divorce, and it was wonderful. Everything about it was new. She shared her culture with me, and I got to learn it from the inside. She cooked for me all the time, one dish after another that I'd never tasted and would never have found on my own. And she stepped into my world just as fully: she learned to mountain bike, to fish, to kayak, and all sorts of other things, simply because they mattered to me. Coming out of a divorce, I hadn't realized how much I needed someone to be curious about my life.

Her girls, Jojo and Jaja, became a big part of it. I loved them like my own, and I grew very close to them. They were so kind to me, and they never had to be. I think of them often, and I wonder how they're doing, what they're learning, who they're becoming. Of everything I lost in these years, losing them is one of the hardest. For a while I had two daughters, and then I didn't.

Lindsay, I owe you an apology, and it comes without excuses. I hurt you. It came from me, not from anything you did, and I know how confusing it must have been to live through. I truly meant to marry you. You waited a long, long time for that, and I know how hard the waiting was. I'm so sorry.

A post like this can make it sound as if illness only takes. What we had was one of the good things, and it was real. Lindsay, thank you for opening your home, your table and your family to me. I carry all of it with me.

Se Jin



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While I was seeing Lindsay, I also had a dear friend, Se Jin. We went hiking together. Every morning I texted her good morning, every night good night, and in between we told each other about our days. We kept that up for months, probably six of them.

Then the depression came, and I ghosted her. There was no decision in it. I just went quiet, the way I described above, when answering a text feels like lifting a car. From her side, someone who had checked in every morning and every night for half a year simply disappeared.

About a month ago we found each other again, and she picked it right back up as if we'd never stopped being friends. No hard feelings. Nothing.

Se Jin, I'm sorry for the silence. You deserved so much better than someone who simply vanished, and you forgave it before I had even found the words to ask.

That kind of grace is rarer than it should be. She is a wonderful, wonderful person, and a wonderful mom to her three sons. I'm so thankful to have her in my life again, and her cute dog, Gracie, too.

Yu



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Yu trusted me. I think of that first, because trust was exactly what I'd been burning through, and she gave it to me anyway. I was the first person she had opened her heart to since her ex.

One day she gave me a key to her apartment. It was a small thing to hold in my hand, and an enormous thing to be given. After everything that came before me, she decided I was someone she could let all the way in. I was deeply moved by it then, more than I knew how to say, and I still am.

Our time together was short, but it changed me, and I'm grateful for every part of it. She let me into her world, and into her son John's.

John came into my life at a moment when it felt like my years of being a dad were ending. My older son was off at college, and my younger son had grown so independent that he didn't really need his dad around anymore. And then there was John. I got to teach him things, to be part of his days, to share in his life. It was a truly happy time, and it gave me back a part of myself I thought I was done with.

The three of us had so much fun together. She took a real interest in me, beyond the fun. She wanted to get me on the right track, and for me that meant stopping the drinking and stopping the partying. She cared where I was headed, and she helped me get there.

She had everything: a kind heart, a sharp mind, and a way of caring that was steady and real. And I was the one who broke it.

I know I hurt her, and I know I hurt her badly. She had been brave enough to trust again. She handed me that trust, and a key to go with it, and I didn't take care of either.

Yu, I know what those nights were like for you. I would leave at ten or eleven and not come home until ten the next morning. No one should ever have to live with that. It wasn't the steady, dependable partner you deserved, and it wasn't the

example John deserved to see. It should never have been yours to carry. I am so deeply sorry.

If she were ever open to a friendship, it would be one of the most wonderful things I could hope for. She is one of the kindest, most caring and most thoughtful people I have known, and a wonderful mother.

Yu, thank you. For your trust, for your time, and for caring where I was headed.

Jason and Michelle



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If this story has a hero, it's my brother Jason.

There were stretches when my routine fell apart, and through them I texted Jason every day with what I'd done. He read every one, and he kept me on track. It sounds small. It wasn't. Knowing someone would notice if I slipped, or went quiet, held me up on days when nothing else did.

He helped me with my finances when I couldn't face them. He helped me through my divorce.

And it isn't just me. Jason goes above and beyond for our whole family. When our dad was dying, Jason figured it out. Our dad's mental illness, and everything it brought with it: Jason figured it out. Now our mom is going through dementia and memory loss, and again Jason is the one figuring it out. Whenever everything gets messed up, he works out what has to happen, and then he does it.

He is selfless. He gives everything he has to his family.

And he doesn't do it alone. His wife, Michelle, my sister, is right beside him. She supports him in everything, and together they are a perfect team. The two of them just get things done. They've done it for me, for Mom, for Dad, for everyone.

He has also dealt with me lying to him. He was on the receiving end of some of the lies I described earlier. And he has kept supporting me, without question, every time.

Jason and Michelle: none of this goes unrecognized. I see what you've done for me, for Dad, for Mom, for all of us, and I don't say it nearly often enough. Thank you, both of you.

This is me telling Jason what he means to me.

Getting help, and how long it took



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For years I treated the symptoms I could name. In early 2022 I did several months of weekly therapy for generalized anxiety and was on a low-dose SSRI (citalopram). It helped the anxiety. It didn't touch the bigger pattern.

In the fall of 2022 I had an episode that was completely out of character for me, and I recognized it. It looked exactly like what I'd seen growing up with my father. That scared me into acting. I emailed a long list of therapists, asked specifically for someone experienced with bipolar disorder, and told them plainly: *My first goal is an assessment. I need to know if I am in fact bipolar.*

I was diagnosed in December 2022.

Here's the honest version of what came next, because I think the tidy version hurts people.

Medications: trial, error, and patience

Finding treatment that works is rarely one prescription. For me it has been a long run of adjustments:

- **Citalopram** (an SSRI), for anxiety, before the diagnosis.
- **Cariprazine (Vraylar)**, an atypical antipsychotic approved for bipolar depression. I started at 1.5 mg, and in early 2023 we moved up to 3 mg.
- **Fluoxetine (Prozac)**, with dose increases when the depression and anxiety came back hard.
- **Ketamine infusions**, starting in late 2023, when the depression wasn't responding. The first few gave me a real, noticeable clearing. Later ones were less effective, and one was a genuinely bad experience.
- **TMS (transcranial magnetic stimulation)** in 2024, recommended by my psychiatrist after medication and ketamine hadn't been enough.

None of these was a magic switch. Some helped for a while. Some had side effects I had to weigh against the benefit. Every change meant weeks of waiting to see whether it was working. The most important thing I've learned is that **“this medication didn't work” is information, not failure.** It narrows the search.

Work, brain fog, and leaves of absence



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I've been a software engineer and architect for decades. My identity is wrapped up in being the person who can hold a whole system in his head. Depression takes that away first.

The brain fog is hard to explain to people who haven't had it. You read the same paragraph five times. You open a file and forget why. A design problem you'd normally solve on a walk just doesn't resolve. It's like thinking through wet cement. Then you blame yourself for being slow, which feeds the depression.

I've had to take **multiple medical leaves of absence**:

- In **spring 2023**, a few months after my diagnosis, while we worked on medication.
- From **late September to mid-December 2023**, for severe depression.
- Again in **late 2024**.

Writing the email to my team that said “I’ve been dealing with severe depression” was one of the scariest things I’ve done professionally. The response was kinder than I expected. Taking leave was treatment. It was not quitting.

The label, and whether it’s right

I promised the honest version, so here’s the complicated part.

In late 2024 my psychiatrist and my psychologist both told me they no longer believed the bipolar diagnosis was correct. They thought much of what looked like mania in late 2022 was tangled up with grief and trauma I hadn’t dealt with, rather than a mood disorder on its own.

I’m writing this post anyway, and I kept “bipolar” in the title, for a few reasons:

- **Diagnosis in psychiatry is hard.** There’s no blood test. Bipolar II in particular is often misdiagnosed as plain depression, and trauma responses can be mistaken for bipolar. Many people go years, sometimes a decade, before the label fits.
- **The experiences were real.** The sleepless highs, the gym twice a day, the clubs, the aggression, the lying, the friends gained and lost, the crashes, the fog, the leaves from work. Whatever the name, I lived it, and so did the people around me.
- **I have a family history that makes me take it seriously.** I’d rather be vigilant and wrong than dismissive and wrong.

What I've learned is to hold the label loosely and the treatment tightly.



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I don't have a neat ending. I'm still in treatment, still learning my patterns, still repairing relationships. But I'm here, I'm present for my boys, and I don't want to hide any of this from the people who matter to me anymore.

To everyone named in this post, and to the many who aren't: thank you for the part you played. Whether you're still in my life or not, you are part of how I got here, and I'm grateful for every one of you.